SURVEY SHARK

Downloading Your Responses

How to save the survey responses you collected and open them in Microsoft Excel

For student researchers who collected data with Survey Shark.
You'll need: your Student Researcher ID, the access code, and an internet connection.

What you'll do

1	Download your file from **My progress** in Survey Shark	Section 2
2	Find the downloaded file on your phone or computer	Section 3
3	Open it in Excel (two methods)	Section 4
4	Save it as a proper Excel workbook (.xlsx)	Section 5
5	Make it easy to read: freeze headers, filter, tidy columns	Section 6

Easiest route: use a laptop or desktop computer

Excel works best on a computer. You can open Survey Shark in any web browser on a laptop (it doesn't have to be the phone you collected on) — enter the same access code and Student Researcher ID, and the download will include every response you submitted from any device. The file is saved straight into your computer's **Downloads** folder, ready to open in Excel.

1. Before you start

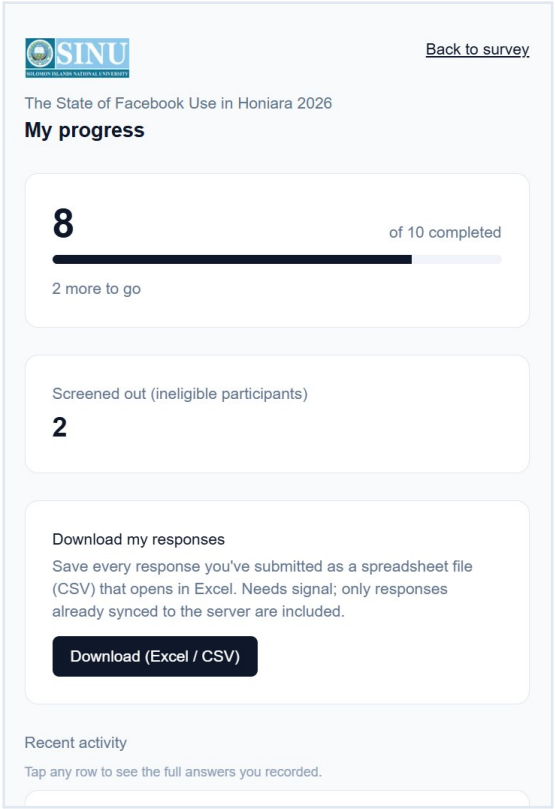
- **Make sure everything has synced.** The download only includes responses that have reached the server. On the phone you collected with, open Survey Shark while you have signal and check the bar at the top says **“0 waiting to sync”**. If not, tap **Sync now** and wait for it to reach 0.
- **Have internet or mobile data.** Downloading needs a connection — it won't work offline.
- **Have your codes ready** if you're using a new device: the web address, access code, and your Student Researcher ID (see the front page of your Field Collector Guide).

Keep this file private

Your file contains participants' answers. Treat it like your paper questionnaires: do not post it on Facebook, WhatsApp groups or other social media, don't share it with anyone outside your research team, and delete it from shared or public computers (e.g. internet cafés, library PCs) when you're done.

2. Download your responses

1. Open your browser (Chrome, Safari, Edge…) and go to the Survey Shark web address your supervisor gave you.
2. Tap or click the survey you collected for (e.g. *The State of Facebook Use in Honiara 2026*).
3. If asked, enter the **Access code** and your **Student Researcher ID** and tap **Continue**. (On the phone you used for fieldwork you're usually already signed in.)
4. Tap **My progress** (top of the survey screen) to open your dashboard. If the survey has closed, you can also go straight to the web address followed by **/dashboard**, for example `…/collect/facebook-honiara-2026/dashboard`.
5. Find the **Download my responses** box and tap **Download (Excel / CSV)**.
6. Wait a few seconds while it says **Preparing…** — your file then downloads automatically.



The "Download my responses" box on your My progress dashboard (sample data shown).

The file is named like `facebook-honiara-2026-YOUR-ID-responses.csv`. It contains **only your own** responses — both completed and screened-out participants.

If you see an error message



This appears when there's no connection. Move to an area with signal or wifi and tap Download again.

3. Find the downloaded file

Device	Where your file goes
Windows laptop/PC	Your **Downloads** folder. Open **File Explorer** (yellow folder icon) › **Downloads**. Chrome and Edge also show the file at the top-right of the browser — click it to open.
Mac	The **Downloads** folder (in the Dock or in Finder's sidebar).
Android phone (Chrome)	A “Download complete” message appears at the bottom — tap **Open**. Later, find it in the **Files** (or **My Files**) app › **Downloads**.
iPhone (Safari)	Tap the **download arrow** in the address bar › **Downloads**. Later, open the **Files** app › **On My iPhone** (or iCloud Drive) › **Downloads**.

Moving the file from your phone to a computer

The simplest option is to repeat Section 2 on the computer instead. If you can't, send the file to yourself: in your phone's Files app, tap and hold the file › **Share** › choose **Gmail/Email** (send to your own address) or **Google Drive / OneDrive**. Then download it on the computer. Only send it to yourself — see the privacy note in Section 1.

Only have a phone?

You can open the file in the free **Microsoft Excel** app (Android/iPhone) or **Google Sheets**: open the app, choose **Open** / **Browse**, and pick the file from Downloads. Reading and filtering works, but sections 4–6 are much easier on a computer.

4. Open the file in Excel

Your file is a **CSV** (comma-separated values) file — a plain spreadsheet format that Excel, Google Sheets and SPSS can all open. There are two ways to open it.

Method A — double-click (quickest)

1. Go to your **Downloads** folder.
2. Double-click the `…-responses.csv` file. It opens in Excel with each question in its own column.
3. If Windows asks which app to use, choose **Excel** and tick **Always use this app**.

Method B — Import with "From Text/CSV" (use if Method A looks wrong)

Use this if everything appears squashed into column A, or you see odd characters like â€″ instead of dashes.

1. Open Excel and create a **Blank workbook**.
2. Click the **Data** tab on the ribbon at the top.
3. Click **From Text/CSV** (in the *Get & Transform Data* group, at the far left). On older Excel versions it's **Data** › **Get External Data** › **From Text**.
4. Select your `…-responses.csv` file and click **Import**.
5. In the preview window set **File Origin** to **65001: Unicode (UTF-8)** and **Delimiter** to **Comma**. The preview should show proper columns.
6. Click **Load**. Your responses appear in a new sheet as a formatted table.

What you should see

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	**Response ID**	**Survey version**	**Status**	**Terminated at question**	**Submitted at (UTC)**	**ADMIN_PARTICIPANT_CODE: Participant code**	**B1: What is your age group?**
2	301	1.0.0	completed		2026-10-02T00:27:52.046Z	SAMPLE-P01	25–34
3	317	1.0.0	completed		2026-10-02T03:10:05.512Z	SAMPLE-P02	18–24
4	342	1.0.0	screened_out	A2	2026-10-03T01:44:19.003Z	SAMPLE-P03	

Example only — made-up sample data. Your real file has one column for every question (about 180 columns) and one row for every participant you submitted.

5. Save it as an Excel workbook (.xlsx)

A CSV file can't store formatting, column widths, filters, extra sheets or charts. Save a proper Excel copy before you start working on it:

1. Click **File** › **Save As** (or press **F12**).
2. Choose where to save it, e.g. **Documents** or your OneDrive folder.

3. Give it a clear name, e.g. `My survey responses - 700012345.xlsx`.
4. In **Save as type**, choose **Excel Workbook (*.xlsx)**.
5. Click **Save**. From now on, open and work in this .xlsx file, not the CSV.

> **“Some features might be lost” warning**
>
> If Excel shows a yellow bar or a pop-up about the CSV format losing features, it means you are still saving as CSV. Use **Save As** and pick **Excel Workbook (*.xlsx)** as described above.

6. Make it easy to read

Your sheet is very wide (one column per question). These steps make it much easier to work with.

Keep the question headings visible while scrolling

1. Click the **View** tab.
2. Click **Freeze Panes** › **Freeze Top Row**. Row 1 (the questions) now stays on screen when you scroll down.
3. Optional: click cell **F2**, then **Freeze Panes** › **Freeze Panes** to also keep columns A–E (Response ID to Submitted at) visible when you scroll right.

Show only completed responses (filter)

1. Click any cell in row 1, then click **Data** › **Filter** (skip this if you used Method B — filters are already on). Small arrows appear in each heading.
2. Click the arrow on the **Status** column.
3. Untick **screened_out** so only **completed** is ticked, then click **OK**.
4. To show everything again: click the arrow › **Clear Filter**.

Tidy the columns

- **Readable headings:** click the row number **1** to select the heading row, then **Home** › **Wrap Text**.
- **Fit column widths:** click the triangle in the top-left corner of the grid to select everything, then **Home** › **Format** › **AutoFit Column Width**.
- **Count answers quickly:** select a column — Excel shows the **Count** at the bottom-right of the window. For a full breakdown use **Insert** › **PivotTable**.

7. Understanding the columns

Each **row** is one participant. Each **column** heading starts with the question code from the questionnaire (e.g. **B1**) followed by the question text.

Column	What it means
Response ID	The server's reference number for this response. Quote it if you ask your supervisor about a particular response.
Survey version	Which version of the questionnaire was used (normally the same for everyone).
Status	**completed** — full interview. **screened_out** — the participant was not eligible and the survey ended early.
Terminated at question	For screened-out participants, the screening question that ended the survey (e.g. A1). Blank for completed responses.
Submitted at (UTC)	When the response reached the server, in UTC time — e.g. `2026-10-02T00:27:52Z`. Add **11 hours** for Solomon Islands time (that example is 11:27am on 2 Oct).
ADMIN_… columns	The collection details you entered: participant code, your Student ID, date, area and mode of completion.
Single-answer questions	One column showing the answer chosen, e.g. **B1** = *25–34*.
“Tick all that apply” questions	One column **per option** (heading ends with “— *option*”). **1** = ticked; blank = not ticked.
Grid / rating questions	One column per row of the grid, showing the rating chosen for that row.
“Other (specify)” columns	The text you typed when the participant chose “Other”.
Blank cells	Not asked or not answered — e.g. questions skipped, or everything after the screening questions for a screened-out participant.

Don't edit the original data

Keep an untouched copy of the downloaded file. Do any cleaning, charts or calculations in your .xlsx copy (or on a new sheet), so you can always go back to the original if something goes wrong.

8. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
“Couldn't download right now — you need signal”	You're offline. Connect to wifi or mobile data and tap **Download** again.
Some of my responses are missing	They probably haven't synced yet. On the phone you collected with, open Survey Shark with signal, wait for **“0 waiting to sync”** (or tap **Sync now**), then download again.
The file only has a heading row	No synced responses were found for the ID you entered. Check you typed your Student Researcher ID exactly as on the roster, then contact your supervisor.
Everything is in column A	Open it with **Method B** (Section 4) and choose **Delimiter: Comma**.
Strange characters (e.g. â€″)	Open it with **Method B** and set **File Origin** to **65001: Unicode (UTF-8)**.
Nothing happens when I tap Download (iPhone)	Wait for **Preparing…** to finish, then check the download arrow in Safari's address bar. If it still fails, try from a computer.
Can't find the file	Look in **Downloads** (Section 3), or search your device for `responses.csv`.
Anything else	Contact your supervisor.

Tagio tumas — thank you for your hard work collecting this data.